the war started. It's only me and my older sister."

He seemed to withdraw, looking down at the ground. As the silence stretched, a ripple of uncertainty flickered in her chest. Had she been wrong to tell him the truth? She didn't know how to read people the way Léa did. She preferred to keep them at a distance, observing them as if they were objects to draw. It was safer that way, less chance of a misunderstanding. After an extended silence during which Rose had not dared to move, André finally looked up.

"I'm sorry about your parents. It must be hard on you and your sister."

Relief flooded her body. At least she hadn't said the *wrong* thing. The pencil slipped from her fingers. As André leaned down to pick it up, his hand brushed her skin and a strip of heat, like a fever, surged along Rose's arm. "It's your turn to draw," she said, wanting this time together to last.

On an empty page, he sketched the stone wall between the canal and the embankment. His lines were straight and solid, fast one moment, slow the next. In the lift of his arm, there was that lightness again, reminding her of the skaters who came to the river in winter, weaving gentle arcs across the glassy ice. Her drawings seemed clumsy and heavy in comparison. He drew the bridge that crossed the canal and the wide steps leading down to the river. And then, he looked at her.

"I hadn't realized . . ." he said, smiling. "Let me see how . . ." he turned back to the paper where he'd begun to sketch her face in the corner. "Your forehead and the distance between your eyes, the proportions of your face are lovely."

It made her dizzy to hear him talk like that, and it was the first time she could get a good look at him—his blue eyes beaming warmth and light, the slight curl of his hair and his mouth opening and closing as his hand skated over the paper. There was so much she didn't know about André, but in her heart, she felt the core of him revealed to her in this moment. She sat still and quiet, taking him in. When she glanced at the paper, she was stunned to find her face staring back at her. He'd somehow seen inside her, too. The moment was sharp and tense, but she sensed it coming to an end, like holding her breath—it couldn't go on, even though she wanted it to.

The bell tower on the church in the nearby village rang the hour. André's hand went still and a flicker of hesitation crossed his face. He closed the sketchbook and gave it back to her. "I've got to go. I'm expected